And I was there, the ball in my hand, putting it down on the spot. *What have I said? What have I done?*

I was glad Collina was in charge. He wasn't going to let anybody mess about here in Sapporo. South American players are very good at putting pressure on you, at trying to intimidate and unsettle opponents. I had good reason to know that better than most, so it didn't surprise me. The ref, the keeper and Diego Simeone, of all people, were standing in front of me, between me and the goal. I took two or three steps back. Simeone walked straight past the ball towards me. He stopped and offered his hand as if he expected me to shake it. *Should I? No chance.*

I looked beyond him—through him—towards the goal, trying to blank him out. Then, as I turned, Butty and Scholesy came from behind me and pulled Simeone away. *My mates. I like that.*

I looked down at the ball before running up. It all went quiet. Everything was swirling around me, every nerve standing on edge. *What's going on here? I can't breathe…*

I remember forcing in two big gulps of air to try and steady myself and take control. For the last two penalties I'd taken for United, I'd hit the ball straight down the middle of the goal and the keepers, diving to one side, had been nowhere near them. *Same again now, David*. I was far too nervous to try to be clever. Not nervous for myself any longer. This was all about the team I was captain of. I've never felt such pressure before. I ran forward. And I kicked the ball goalwards as hard as I could.

In.

The roar.

IN!

Not the best penalty kick you've ever seen. But, for me, for all of us that night, just absolutely perfect. I'd run up, hit it and—knowing, instinctively, it was a goal—kept on running towards the corner flag. The nerves, the pressure and four years of memories just fell away. In those few seconds after the ball settled in the back of Argentina's net, I could see flashbulbs fire off around the ground. As each little explosion died against the blur and color of the stands, it took everything that had happened, everything that had been said or written since my red card in Saint-Etienne, away into the night sky with it.